campaign trail—it was now clearly a major, possibly terror, attack on a rally of the BJP's prime ministerial candidate.

Modi was just landing in Patna when the blasts occurred. BJP president Rajnath Singh and Arun Jaitley had already arrived. Jaitley was staying at the Maurya Hotel that overlooks the maidan. 'As a result, I reached the venue a little early,' recalled Jaitley. He was met by a senior officer of the Gujarat police who was handling Modi's security (the Centre still hadn't given him special Z category cover). 'Sir, we are asking Modiji to stay at the airport and not come to the venue. The rally will have to be cancelled,' the officer told Jaitley. The BJP leader consulted with Rajnath Singh and the duo decided to stay put. 'If we call off the rally, there will be total panic and people could die in a stampede,' was their fear.

The local Bihar police, which had clearly made inadequate security preparations, was asked to prepare for an emergency situation in case there was another blast near the stage. Four cars were lined up behind the main podium to whisk the top BJP leadership away in any such eventuality. Modi by now had arrived on the stage and the crowd began roaring his name out, almost oblivious to the crisis brewing around them. 'It was a bizarre situation. Serial blasts had taken place, but the crowd just wanted a glimpse of Modi,' remembers a senior police officer. 'I hadn't seen anything like this.'

Knowing the urgency of the situation, Jaitley completed his speech in just seven minutes. Rajnath Singh, who had promised to complete his address speedily too, took twenty minutes. The crowd was getting restive; the police increasingly worried. That's when Modi took over.

In a forty-five-minute speech, laced with phrases in the local Maithili and Bhojpuri dialects, Modi proceeded to tear into Nitish Kumar's government, calling the chief minister an 'opportunist' and a 'hypocrite'. 'Nitish Kumar has betrayed Bihar. He even betrayed his mentors Jayaprakash Narayan and Ram Manohar Lohia. How can anyone trust such a man!' he bellowed.

Modi emphasized his backward-caste credentials. 'Congress leaders don't know what poverty and hunger are. I used to sell tea on trains. I know how difficult it is to get onto trains and make a living. Even the railway